Federal Office
for Migration
and Refugees

First steps in Germany

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Just arrived in Germany? You need to know the following:

The residents' registration office



Link to the information hotline "working and living in Germany"
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Registration with the local residents' registration office (*Einwohnermeldeamt*) is compulsory in Germany. You must be registered in order to receive a tax identification number, for example. You will need to register within two weeks of taking up residence in an apartment. It is important to require confirmation from your landlord for this purpose. You will receive a registration certificate when you register.

The immigration authorities

If you are a third-country national, you must go to the immigration authority in person after arriving in Germany in order to apply for a residence title. The residence title will be issued according to the purpose of your stay, in the form of an electronic card (electronic residence title).

Health insurance

It is mandatory to have statutory or private health insurance in Germany. The health insurance fund covers the costs of any medical treatment that may be necessary.

Training, education and studying

A variety of learning and educational opportunities are available to your family members who accompany you to Germany. Your dependents can take up training or studies if they meet the relevant requirements; your children can go to school free of charge.

Important information

All children and juveniles living in Germany are **required to attend school**. Depending on the Federal Land, they usually have to attend a general education school for at least **nine years from the age of six onwards**. Children and juveniles with disabilities or special educational needs are also able to attend school.

The competent education authority is responsible for deciding on the enrolment of newly-immigrated children. They may also enrol intra-year.

The majority of schools are state-run and thus free of charge.

The following is also important:

- **Opening a bank account:** It makes sense to open a German bank account if you stay for a prolonged period in Germany. This makes it easier to transfer payments, such as rent and wages.
- **Validation of your driving licence:** You can drive in Germany for up to six months with a foreign driving licence. You may be required to acquire a German driving licence after six months.

Further information

Texts and articles

Family

Advice for adults

Integration courses

Links

Web portal "Recognition in Germany"

Federal Ministry of Finance

Jobbörse of the Federal Employment Agency

Make it in Germany: Looking for housing

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